FOR THE HIGHLANDS · OCTOBER 5 – NOVEMBER 29, 2026

Endurance for the trip

Eight weeks. The goal is to walk the Chicabal stairs slowly and still have legs the next day. Each strength exercise has a picture: start on the left, finish on the right. The dark figure is you. The brown arrow is the part that moves.

Knees. Muscle tiredness is fine. Sharp pain, swelling, or a knee that complains the next morning means that move is out.

Diabetes. Check your glucose the way you already do. If you feel low, stop and treat it. Keep juice in the room.

Thyroid. On a flat day: 10 easy minutes on the elliptical, one set of sit-to-stands, one set of glute bridges, and step-downs only if the knee is quiet. Then stop. That day counts. Do not double the next day.

Pictures. Match the finish position, then come back to the start with the same control. If your back rounds or the knee caves in, you have gone too far.

The week

Monday	Strength A, hike legs. About 35 minutes. Optional 10 easy minutes on the elliptical after.
Tuesday	Elliptical, steady. A pace where you can say a full sentence.
Wednesday	Rest.
Thursday	Strength B. About 30 minutes.
Friday	Elliptical hills.
Saturday	Long elliptical. Skip it if you are wiped out, and add 10 minutes to Tuesday.
Sunday	Rest.

Weeks of October 5 and October 12: two sets. From October 19: three sets. Rest about a minute. Start with the empty bar. Elliptical shoes are the Ultraboosts. Once a week, wear the beige trail shoes for a flat 20-minute walk outside.

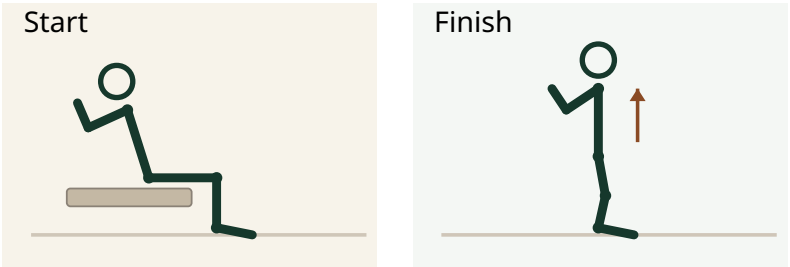
Strength A — hike legs

Monday. Warm up with 5 easy minutes on the elliptical.

KNEES AND GETTING OUT OF A CHAIR

Sit-to-stand

Use the flat bench. Feet flat, about hip width. Lean forward a little, stand up using the legs, then sit back down slowly. 8 to 10 reps. Arms can reach forward. Use your thighs for a hand only if you need it.

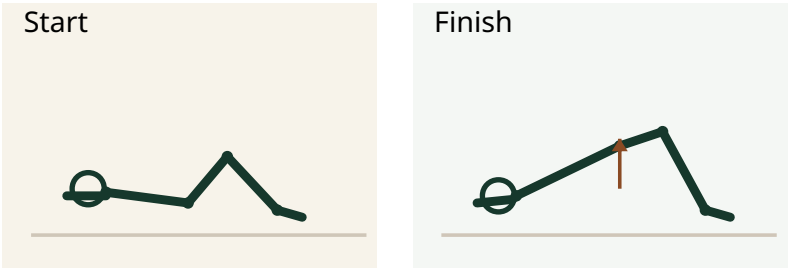


Check: you are tall at the top, knees soft, not locked. The knees point the same way as the toes.

THE MUSCLES THAT PROTECT THE KNEES

Glute bridge

On the mat, on your back, heels close to your hips. Lift the hips, squeeze the seat, lower slowly. 10 reps. When that is easy, rest the empty bar across the hips.



Check: shoulders stay on the mat. Hips lift until the body is a straight line from shoulders to knees. Do not arch the low back higher than that.

PICKING THINGS UP ON A TRAIL

Hip hinge

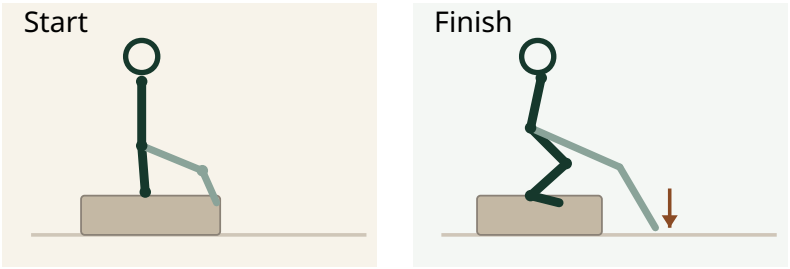
Empty bar in front of the thighs. Soft knees, push the hips back, chest stays proud, bar stays against the legs. Stop before the back wants to round. Stand by pushing the floor away. 8 reps.

Check: the hips travel backward, more than the knees travel forward. The bar stays close to the legs. This is not a squat.

THE CHICABAL STAIRS

Step-down, on the tile step by the door

Hold the wall. Stand on the low step on one foot. Lower the other foot toward the floor over a slow count of three. Touch lightly and come back up. 6 each leg.

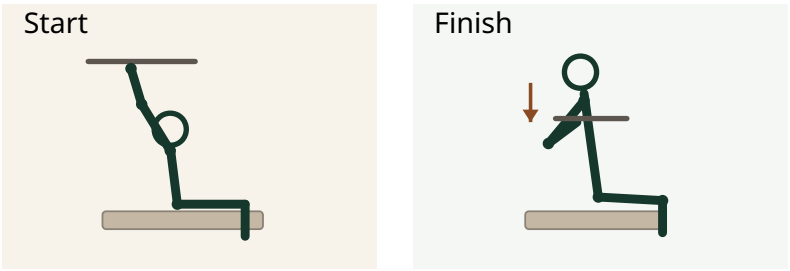


Check: the knee of the standing leg stays over the foot. It does not cave inward. Only bend as far as that knee stays lined up. The tile step is low enough. Do not use a higher box.

ON THE HOME GYM

Lat pulldown

Sit tall. Start with the arms up, pull the bar toward the upper chest, then let it rise with control. 10 reps.



Check: a small lean is enough. Do not swing the body back to yank the bar. Elbows come down, not way behind you.

CARRYING A BAG WHILE YOU WALK

Farmer hold

A plate in each hand, or the empty bar in front of you. Stand tall for 30 seconds. Two times.

Check: ribs quiet, shoulders down away from the ears, knees soft. You are standing, not leaning.

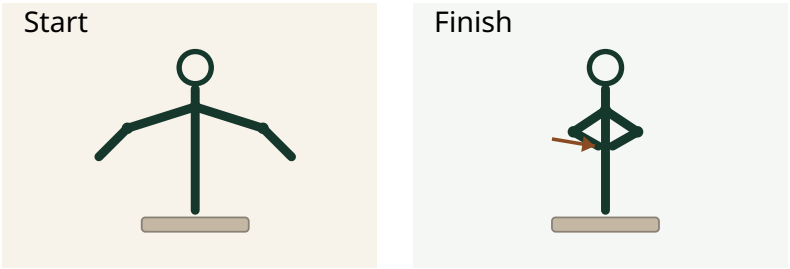
Strength B — support

Thursday. Warm up with 5 easy minutes on the elliptical.

ON THE HOME GYM

Pec deck, light

Sit against the pad. Arms start open, elbows softly bent, then bring the hands toward each other in front of the chest. 10 reps. If the shoulders complain, skip this and do push-ups with your hands on the bench, body in a straight line, 8 reps.

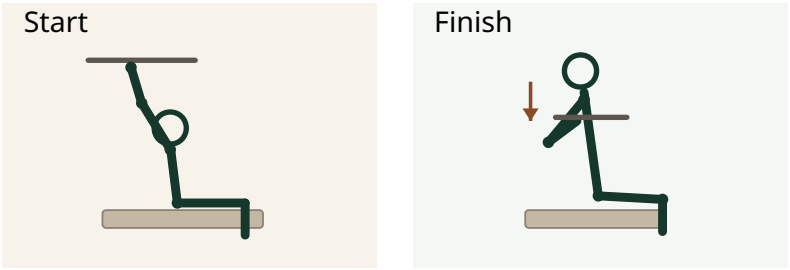


Check: the arms never travel behind the shoulders. Stop the opening while it still feels easy.

ON THE HOME GYM

Lat pulldown, or a seated row

10 reps. If the machine has a low pulley, row on Thursday and save the pulldown for Monday. Same rule: pull to the chest, no yank.

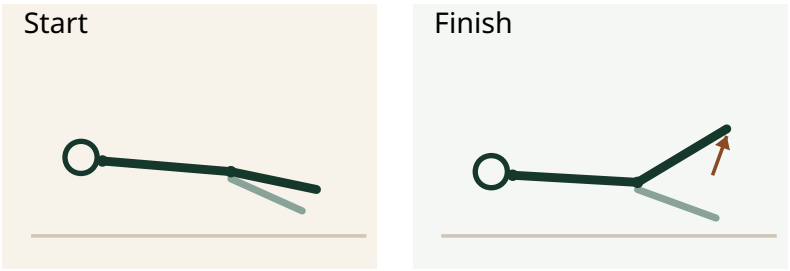


Check: use the pulldown picture above. Shoulders come back at the end, then return slowly.

HIPS

Side leg lift

Lie on the mat on your side, hips stacked. Lift the top leg slightly back, not so high that the hip rolls. Lower slowly. 10 each side.

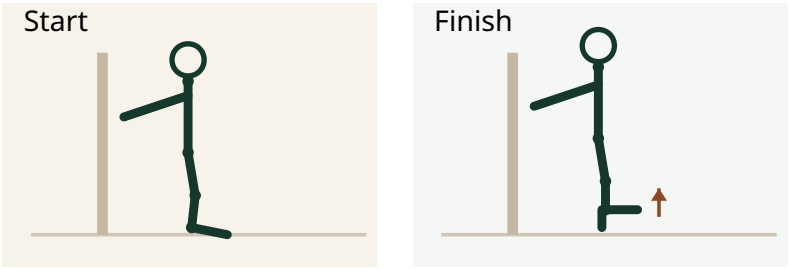


Check: the top foot stays level. Do not let the toes point at the ceiling. A small lift is the whole exercise.

LOWER LEGS

Calf raise

Hold the rack. Rise onto the forefeet, then lower the heels slowly. 12 reps, both feet. One foot only later, and only if the knee is happy.

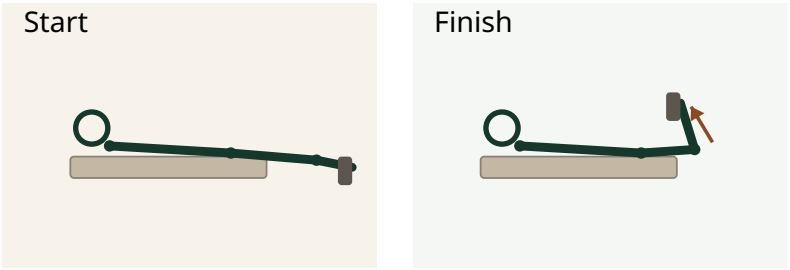


Check: the knees stay almost straight and quiet. This is not a squat. The heels come up, the body stays tall.

ONLY IF IT IS PAINLESS

Light hamstring curl

Lie face down so the hips stay on the bench and the roller sits on the back of the ankles. Bend the knees to bring the heels up, then straighten slowly. Very light, 10 reps. Skip heavy leg extensions.

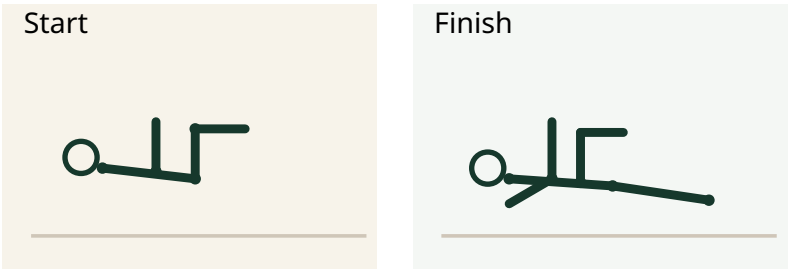


Check: the hips and the stomach stay on the bench. If the knee hurts at all, leave the station alone.

TRUNK, FOR A LONG WALK

Dead bug

On your back, arms toward the ceiling, knees bent so the shins are parallel to the floor. Lower the opposite arm and leg. The low back stays on the mat. 6 each side.

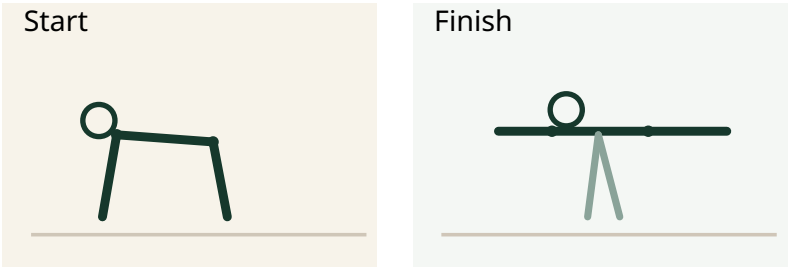


Check: the back does not peel off the mat. If it does, the arm and the leg went too low. Hover higher.

TRUNK, FOR A LONG WALK

Bird dog

On hands and knees, back flat. Reach the opposite arm and leg until they are about level with the back. Hips stay still. 6 each side.



Check: the back stays flat. Do not sag, and do not lift the leg higher than the hip.

Elliptical

Keep the stride comfortable. If more resistance makes you pound or lock the knees, turn it down. You are practicing hours of walking.

Weeks	Tuesday steady	Friday hills	Saturday long
Oct 5 and Oct 12	30 min, your usual pace	8 min easy, then 2 hard / 2 easy, four times	30 min continuous
Oct 19 and Oct 26	35 min	Five rounds	35, then 40 min
Nov 2 and Nov 9	35–40 min	Six rounds	45 min. On Nov 9, sling for the last 10.
Nov 16	40 min	Six rounds	50 min, sling for the last 15.
Nov 23	30 min easy	Four easy rounds	40 min easy, no sling. Taper week.

If you already do more than 30 minutes, stay there for the first two weeks. Add 5 minutes to the long day every two weeks. “Hard” means you can still say a short sentence.

Cerro Quemado on December 5 is the short walk. Chicabal on December 6 is the staircase. The step-downs are for that staircase. Xela is much higher than San Salvador, so the first hills will feel thin even if the legs are ready. Walk slowly.

November 30 and December 1: 20 easy minutes, or rest. No new exercises. No heavy step-downs.